responsibility for the operations was transferred from the Central Intelligence Agency to the United States Air Force.

Historians disagree about whether earlier discovery of the missiles made an appreciable difference to how the crisis developed. Certainly, the Kennedy administration sensed domestic political problems and subsequently went to some lengths to disguise the reasons for its actions, claiming the paucity of missions during September was entirely due to poor weather. When the flights resumed on Sunday, 14 October, a USAF U-2 piloted by Major Richard Heyser succeeded in photographing missile sites in western Cuba. By the following day, US photo-analysts were convinced they had discovered Soviet MRBMs. News began to reach senior administration officials during the evening. McGeorge Bundy decided there was no need to tell an exhausted President until the morning, Tuesday, 16 October.

The US intelligence community's assessment that the Soviets would not deploy nuclear missiles (or nuclear submarines) in Cuba is frequently cited as an intelligence failure. Raymond Garthoff describes it as a 'failure of estimative empathy'.[86] Garthoff, himself argues, however, that while 'more weight and attention' should have been given to the possibility of Soviet nuclear deployment 'a more open-ended and cautionary SNIE would have made no essential difference'.[87] As James Blight and David Welch note, 'the US intelligence community made such an intense effort to look for something that they did not expect to see.'[88]

Elephant in the room?

Historians continue to disagree about the relative importance of the different calculations behind Khrushchev's original idea to deploy nuclear missiles. If, after sixty years, this is still being debated, Western leaders and intelligence officials can hardly be blamed if they struggled to fathom Moscow's exact objectives. Yet, understanding Soviet goals was crucial to how the crisis should be managed. What is striking about perceptions in the White House is that Berlin was seen as key to Khrushchev's ambitions. The idea that a central Soviet aim was to defend Cuba was barely considered.